with his hands, as if to tell the world – or was it himself? – that the Niru'un who ruled Hindustan was neither weakened nor scared.

The fact is, however, that no matter his incontestable wealth and power, Akbar could no longer command the strength and reckless self-confidence of his youth. And it wasn't only the inevitable decay of age that was beginning to hamper his stride, it was also the weight of his responsibilities.

One of the many minor keys that sounds in the overwhelming symphony of information, opinion and symbol that comprises the *Akbarnama* is Akbar's desire to see the snow. It would have reminded him of his childhood. When Akbar left Kabul with his father, he was twelve years old, and he first returned to the city in 1581, just shy of forty. At the time, however, his half-brother Hakim was threatening to ally with Abdullah of Turan, so Akbar spent only a few days in what had once been home. Again, in 1589, before his accidents with horse and elephant, Akbar had visited Kabul at greater leisure. This time, he had hoped to show the 'active young men' in his service some snowfall, have them 'tread the ice', thinking that his Hindustani mansabdars 'might enjoy this'.

Perhaps, in Akbar's freewheeling boyhood, the prince had skated on Kabul's frozen waters, bombarded his tutors and ataliq with snowballs. This time, however, it was Abdullah of Turan himself who was becoming restive at the thought of Akbar so close to his border; and Akbar left before the snow arrived. Three years later, in the month of his fiftieth birthday, October 1592, then again in 1597, Akbar was in Kashmir, hoping to see the winter in his new pleasure retreat, if not in his old home. Both times, however, the emperor realized that his men were not enjoying the cold as he wanted them to, and abandoned his plans.[38]

'Students well versed in European history seldom . . . realize,' writes Vincent A. Smith, '. . . that the empire of Akbar during the last quarter of the sixteenth century undoubtedly was the most powerful in the world, and that its sovereign was immeasurably the richest monarch on the face of the earth.'[39] And yet, the richest, most powerful of monarchs – whose proximity caused tremors in Turan, whom the new young king of Persia called 'shah-baba', king-father – would never be free to throw a snowball again.

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